

skillsets needed for systems administration can be divided into layers, says Srivastava. "The entry-level skill required by IT companies in the field of server administration and security is the Red Hat Certified Engineer (RHCE) level. Those who want to enter into the highly challenging area of network securities can acquire the Red Hat Certified Security Specialist (RHCSS) certification. The top certification available in India under the administration and security bracket is Red Hat Certified Architect (RHCA). Those with a sound knowledge of virtualisation are also in demand," he adds. Red Hat offers three levels of training to FOSS experts. "Level 1 goes into the depth of systems administration. Level 2 involves acquiring networking and security skills while Level 3 goes deeper into understanding device issues," says Iyer.

Meanwhile, with 90 per cent of the BPO contact centres in India based on low-cost FOSS technology, skills in Asterisk are much sought after. "The future of business in BPOs depends upon reasonably priced technologies and equally priced expertise to help them manage operations. This has resulted in a demand for FOSS certified resources like Digium Certified Asterisk Professionals (dCAP)," says Limbani.

The route to expertise

But how does one become a FOSS expert? Well, you first need to work on understanding hardware and FOSS on your own, then get trained and certified, after which you must keep abreast with new developments. "Start by downloading FOSS from the Internet and implementing it on a PC or laptop. Use the online community to get support initially. FOSS skills are acquired over a period of time and thus are in high demand," says Bhattacharya.

Thereafter, go in for a certified training programme. "A formal training in FOSS helps professionals sharpen FOSS skills, allowing them to use the tools in a holistic manner. Without the training, one tends to use only the modules one actually works on," says Satish Gopinath, proprietor, Integer Education. A. Saravanan, founder and director, Lynus Academy, says: "FOSS training provides the necessary knowledge and infuses confidence in professionals. It helps them to take on new and emerging technologies faster."

Once you have attained expertise in FOSS, you

Formal training vs self learning

Self-learning, though hailed, is a very lengthy process as one has to totally depend on community support or look out for someone with knowledge in a particular FOSS domain. Formal training eases the learning process. Yet the debate goes on about the self-learning route vs formal training.

While Bhattacharya hails self-learning as a very good route to learning FOSS programming, as it helps overcome mental roadblocks and the diffidence to interact with larger communities, Limbani doubts the self-training mode, as the trainee loses out on learning about the various permutations and combinations that can be applied in a particular FOSS technology.

"Formal training provides you a mentor to look up to in case you are stuck in a particular problem, giving easy access to qualified resources. This helps you dodge the pitfalls in the deployment and service of a particular FOSS project. This results in an overall win-win situation for the professional, the enterprise and the FOSS project," says Limbani. "Nowadays, when cost is not the money but time, formal training helps the professional have time with his side. Formal training helps the candidate learn the tricks that the trainer would have mastered during a lifetime. Further, the edge of getting certifications and industry recognition, helps the candidate in getting a head start," adds Srivastava.

would need to build up the expertise in an open source product to build niche skills. "For example, your value would be more if you call yourself an expert in Magento and Drupal, than a PHP developer," says Minocha.

Looking ahead, with companies replacing previous proprietary solutions with FOSS alternatives, the demand for trained FOSS experts and the need for faster mechanisms to churn out FOSS professionals is only set to grow. So be quick to roll up your sleeves and get to work on FOSS! 

By: Vanisha Joseph

The author loves to experiment and writing for LINUX For You is her latest experiment. So, beware! Just a minute, she also happens to be a journalist during the day.

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